
Under the Hood: How Warner Bros. Discovery Is Actually Building Its AI Capability — 8,700 Miles From Burbank

A look at the inner workings of one entertainment giant’s AI build-out — who is hired, where, at what cost, and for what work — drawn from job postings, government records, corporate filings, salary data, and press on two continents. Not a scandal; a map.

At a glance

- **The gap:** WBD’s CEO says AI is for ads and discovery, “not to create programming”; the company is suing Midjourney. Meanwhile its careers system shows the largest generative-AI hiring footprint of any major studio we measured — 145 open requisitions on our July 22, 2026 review.
- **The geography:** the majority of that hiring is in Hyderabad, India, at a hub WBD calls “fundamental to building our global technology platforms.”
- **The work:** engineering, AI tooling, and content operations — not creative development, which stays in the US.

- **The economics:** a senior WBD engineer in Hyderabad costs roughly a quarter to a fifth of the equivalent US hire.
- **The silence:** celebrated in the Indian press; unmentioned in the US trades and in every congressional hearing on Hollywood job losses.
- **The read:** not a scandal — a map of the new division of labor, with the augmentation interpretation taken seriously throughout.

The finding, in one paragraph

David Zaslav, Chief Executive Officer of Warner Bros. Discovery, has told Hollywood that AI is for ad targeting and content discovery, “not to create programming,” and that “world-class storytelling can only be found in people, not systems” [1]. The company is suing the AI image generator Midjourney for copyright infringement [2]. At the same time, WBD’s careers system lists 145 open positions matching “generative AI” — the largest AI hiring footprint of any major studio we measured — and the center of gravity of that hiring is not Burbank or New York. It is Hyderabad, capital of the south Indian state of Telangana, at a facility WBD’s own careers page describes as “fundamental to building our global technology platforms, which power our suite of products worldwide” [3]. The build-out is not hidden. It is simply not covered — celebrated in India’s Telangana press [4][5], invisible in the American trades, and absent from every congressional hearing held on Hollywood job losses this year [6].

1. The talk

Zaslav has said publicly that AI’s role at WBD is advertising and content discovery, “not to create programming,” and that “world-class storytelling can only be found in people, not systems” [1].

The Midjourney lawsuit, summarized. On September 4, 2025, Warner Bros. Entertainment and four affiliated plaintiffs sued Midjourney, Inc. in the U.S. District Court for the Central District of California [2][7]. The 87-page complaint alleges direct and secondary copyright infringement: that Midjourney’s commercial subscription service generates images and videos of WBD’s copyrighted characters — Superman, Batman, Wonder Woman, Bugs Bunny, Scooby-Doo, Tom and Jerry, the Powerpuff Girls, Rick and Morty — even from prompts that never name them (for example, “classic comic book superhero battle”) [7][8]. The complaint calls the infringement “systematic” and “willful” [8]. In plain terms: WBD alleges Midjourney built a paid product on WBD’s intellectual property without a license. The suit does not concern AI in general — it concerns unlicensed AI. That distinction matters for this report: nothing in the complaint conflicts with WBD building its own AI capability, and the record shows it is doing exactly that. There is also a constructive reading of the suit worth stating plainly: US law on AI training and output is unsettled, and a rights-holder of characters this valuable taking the question to a federal court is one of the ways that law gets clarified — for the whole industry, licensed builders included. A company can sue Midjourney and build AI tooling at the same time without contradiction; the two acts together describe a strategy of licensed, controlled adoption rather than rejection.

2. The walk

- **145 open requisitions matching “generative AI”** in WBD’s Workday careers system as of our July 22, 2026 review — more than Netflix (77 machine-learning requisitions) or Disney (45) (methodology, Section 10). Sony Pictures shows near zero on the same keyword search, but that is a measurement artifact, not abstention: Sony centralizes generative-AI research at the group level (Sony AI in Tokyo, Sony Research India in

Bengaluru) and staffs studio AI under enterprise-IT branding — a newly created “Enterprise Intelligence Platform” organization in Culver City, with an SVP and forward-deployed engineers shipping production AI applications across the studio [46]. Independently corroborated by Glassdoor (~124 WBD Hyderabad openings, May 2026) and Indeed (~200) [9].

- **A note on what a job count can and cannot show.** The 145 figure is a single-day reading of a moving instrument: postings open and close daily, and keyword matching can both over-count (a “generative AI” mention in boilerplate) and under-count (AI roles titled in other language — the Sony case above is the proof). We treat the number as an order-of- magnitude indicator, not a census; the finding that survives any reasonable measurement error is the pattern — WBD’s AI hiring is the largest among the majors on every source we checked (its own portal, Glassdoor, Indeed), and its center of gravity is Hyderabad on all of them. This publication re-runs the count on a recurring basis, and the figure will be re-verified on publication day; a multi-date average will replace the snapshot as our review history accumulates.
- The majority of those roles sit in **Hyderabad**, with additional teams in Bangalore and Pune under WBD’s “India Innovation Hub” banner [3].
- Representative Hyderabad titles: Senior Director, Data Science & AI; Senior Staff, Data Science & Applied AI (AI Center of Excellence); Manager, AI Application Development; Staff Software Engineer, Gen AI & ML; Lead, Responsible AI [9][10].
- WBD’s own description: teams in India are “building the future of Warner Bros. Discovery streaming from the ground up,” and the hub is “fundamental to building our global technology platforms, which power our suite of products worldwide” [3]. This is a global delivery center by the company’s own language — not an India-market unit.

3. What kind of jobs are these? Creative vs. technical

A fair map has to answer: is Hyderabad doing Hollywood's creative work, or building its machinery? The evidence supports a precise answer.

The Hyderabad hub's roles fall into three bands, none of them traditional creative development:

1. **Core engineering and AI** (the largest band): data science, machine learning, generative-AI tooling, streaming platform, customer-data ("C360") and ad-tech systems [9][10][11]. These are technology jobs — the systems layer.
2. **Global Content Operations** (the second band): post-production services, quality control, metadata, localization, and broadcast scheduling for content distributed across 3,000+ platforms, 600 channels, and 18 streaming services in 200+ territories [11][12]. These roles touch content but are operational, not originating: they prepare, package, and route finished programming. Representative titles: Manager, Localization Operations; Director, Broadcast Schedule Operations [12][13].
3. **Business services**: finance, HR, analytics [11].

What Hyderabad is not doing: there are no writers'-room, development, greenlight, or production-creative roles for US-market programming in the listings we examined [9][10][12]. Creative development for the US market — the work of deciding and making shows and films — remains in the US, in Burbank and New York.

Where creative-for-India happens: India-market creative work is booming, but it is not WBD-Hyderabad's job. It runs through separate commercial channels — most visibly JioStar, the Reliance-Disney joint venture, which shipped a 100-episode

generative-AI “Mahabharat” (6.5 million day-one views), and an Indian theatrical AI-generated feature arriving in 2026 [14]. WBD’s India content business (licensing arrangements with local platforms) is likewise a separate commercial operation from the Hyderabad technology hub [3][11].

So the precise reading of “people, not systems”: the people (creative development) stay in the US; the systems (the AI and platform layer) are being built in India. The quote, read against the org chart, is not false — it is a map of the division of labor. What the quote does not say is that the systems being built abroad include the generative-AI tooling that will shape how much human labor future content operations require — and content operations is precisely the band of US media employment that absorbed heavy cuts in 2025 [15][16].

The augmentation reading — taken seriously. There is a version of this arrangement that is simply how creative work is being redefined: human creatives in Hollywood directing, prompting, and fine-tuning AI systems the way an editor directs a researcher — judgment and taste at the top, machinery underneath. Netflix’s own disclosure that generative AI touched roughly 300 of its 2026 titles, under human creative direction, is that model working in public [14]. Nothing in the evidence assembled here rules out that this is exactly what WBD intends: a creative layer in Burbank augmented by a systems layer in Hyderabad, with the humans still deciding what gets made. If so, the facts in this report are not an exposé — they are the specification of that new division of labor, stated more plainly than any of the companies have stated it themselves. What the record does not yet show is the augmented workflow in operation at WBD; that is a question this publication will keep on the board.

4. What do these jobs pay? The arbitrage, in numbers

The economic logic of the geography becomes visible in salary data.

Role (comparable seniority)	United States (LA)	Hyderabad	Ratio
Machine learning engineer, base salary	~\$140,000–165,000 consensus midpoint; Glassdoor average \$179,117 [17][18]	median ~₹12–12.5 lakh (~\$14,500); senior ₹25–50 lakh (~\$30,000–60,000) [19][20]	~4–10x
ML engineer, total compensation	average total comp ~\$288,000–404,000 in top-paying sectors (Built In) [17]	GCC band ₹25–80 lakh (~\$30,000–96,000) incl. equity [19]	~4–8x
WBD Senior Software Engineer specifically	(US SSE comp benchmarks \$180,000–250,000+ total) [17][21]	median total comp ₹40.9 lakh (~\$49,000); range ₹36.4–45.4 lakh; highest reported ₹78.9 lakh (~\$95,000) (Levels.fyi, July 2026) [21]	~4–5x

(Conversions at ~₹83.5/USD. A data-quality note the reader deserves: most rows above are market-level aggregates for comparable roles, not WBD disclosures. The only company-specific figures are the Levels.fyi WBD Hyderabad numbers [21], which are self-reported by employees. WBD does not publish its India compensation; no aggregate source is a substitute for that, and the ratios should be read as ranges, not point estimates.)

Read conservatively: **a senior engineer at WBD Hyderabad costs roughly a quarter to a fifth of the equivalent US hire.** At the hub’s stated capacity of 1,200–1,400 people [22], the annual difference plausibly runs into the hundreds of millions of dollars — an estimate that inherits the market-aggregate caveat

above and is offered as direction and scale, not as a figure from any company's books. Two fairness notes: first, these are strong salaries in the Hyderabad market — top GCCs there pay at or above the local top decile, and these are sought-after jobs [19]; second, salary arbitrage in offshore functions is decades old — American companies have run customer service, telemarketing, payroll, and IT support from India since the 1990s business-process-outsourcing wave, and Hyderabad itself was built partly on that industry. In that sense this is a familiar playbook. The difference is the rung on the ladder: BPO offshored the phone bank; the capability-center wave offshores the engineering department; and what WBD has placed in Hyderabad is the construction of the AI layer itself — the one function most likely to determine everyone else's future headcount. It is also fair — and necessary — to state the ordinary multinational case in full, because cost is rarely the whole story. A Hyderabad engineering hub is unremarkable by the standards of, say, Microsoft or Google, and the non-arbitrage rationales are real: WBD distributes content in 200+ territories and needs round-the-clock platform support that a single US time zone cannot provide; Hyderabad offers one of the deepest data-and-ML talent pools anywhere, at hiring speeds US metros cannot match (the hub went from announcement to inauguration in four months); and follow-the-sun engineering — India's day covering America's night — is standard practice for any global streaming operation. A company could choose Hyderabad for these reasons alone. What makes the build-out reportable here is not the geography but the combination: the specific function (generative AI), the concentration (the company's largest AI hiring footprint), and the distance between the build-out and the company's public account of its AI intentions. The ordinary rationales explain the where; they do not address the gap between the what and the talk.

A note on scale and the H-1B contrast. Hyderabad’s GCC ecosystem overall employs a 300,000+ workforce across 355–400+ capability centers — the fastest-growing GCC city in India [23]. This is the same tech-industry labor pool at the center of the perennial US H-1B visa debate; in this wave, the jobs are not crossing the border in either direction. The work is going to the workers.

5. The timeline — the walk predates the talk

Date	Event	Source
May 17, 2023	WBD announces an International Development Centre in Hyderabad, “expected to create employment for 1,200 professionals.” Deal brokered when Telangana IT Minister K.T. Rama Rao met WBD SVP Finance Alexandra Carter during a US tour.	[4]
Sep 20, 2023	Centre inaugurated at International Tech Park, Hyderabad — four months after announcement. Minister Rama Rao calls it WBD’s “first Greenfield office in Asia after the merger of Warner Media and Discovery.”	[5]
Nov 2024	The ~100,000 sq ft center is WBD’s largest tech hub in India, capacity ~1,200–1,400, framed as a Centre of Excellence for AI-driven consumer analytics, streaming subscription management, and enterprise monetization, with “potential to grow to	[22][11]

Date	Event	Source
	over a couple of thousand people.”	
2024-2025	Zaslav’s “people, not systems” statements harden.	[1]
Jan-Aug 2025	WBD US layoffs: ~200 at CNN (January), linear-TV cuts (June), ~10% of the Motion Picture Group (July-August) ahead of the corporate split into “Warner Bros.” and “Discovery Global.”	[16][24]
Sep 4, 2025	Midjourney suit filed.	[2][7]
Jul 2026	145 open gen-AI requisitions, majority Hyderabad, per our review of WBD’s careers system.	[9]

The Hyderabad center was announced and framed as an AI Center of Excellence **before** most of the public reassurances hardened. The walk predates the talk.

6. Two press ecosystems, one facility

- **Telangana press:** ministers cutting ribbons. “Warner Bros. Discovery’s Hyderabad Capability Centre inaugurated” [5]; “US entertainment giant... to initially employ 1,200” [25]; celebratory Telugu-language coverage describing a “strategic investment centre and growth engine.” No mention of the Zaslav statements or the Midjourney suit in any Indian coverage we reviewed.
- **US trades:** effectively silent. No sustained Hollywood trade coverage of the Hyderabad hub, no mention at congressional hearings on industry job losses, no reference in the runaway-production debate [6][26].

7. The context: what is happening to US media jobs

- **17,000+ US media and entertainment jobs cut in 2025** across TV, film, broadcast, news, and streaming — up 18% year over year [15].
- WBD's share: ~200 CNN jobs, linear-TV cuts, roughly 10% of the Motion Picture Group [16][24].
- LA production context: shoot days fell from 36,792 (2022) to 19,694 (2025); ~41,000 workers left the industry 2022-24; LA County motion-picture employment fell from ~142,000 to ~100,000 [26][27].

The numbers are asymmetrical, and that is the point. A facility of 1,200-1,400 does not absorb 17,000 US cuts, and this report does not claim the jobs “moved” — the layoffs have their own causes (linear-TV decline, the corporate split, post-strike contraction) that predate and exceed any single hub. The narrower, documented finding is one of simultaneity: the AI layer — the tooling that shapes future headcount everywhere — is being built offshore at one-quarter the labor cost during the same period US headcount is cut onshore. Whether those two facts are connected by strategy or only by timing is not in the public record; that they coexist is.

The overlap can be stated more precisely than “simultaneity.” Put the two sides of the ledger next to each other by function. WBD's US cuts hit finance and business affairs (part of the ~1,000-role round of July 2024, which spanned finance, business affairs, production, and Max), content operations and linear television (the 2025 rounds), and streaming and technology staff across multiple rounds [16][24]. WBD's India hubs hire in finance and business services, localization and broadcast-schedule operations, and streaming engineering — a pipeline our review measured in the hundreds of open India listings (~124 on Glassdoor, ~200 on Indeed for Hyderabad alone), against a hub

capacity of 1,200–1,400 [3][9][11][12][22]. These are the same functional bands. What the public record does not support — and this report does not claim — is a one-for-one mapping of any laid-off US position to any Hyderabad requisition: no WARN filing names India as a destination, and no first-hand accounts of US employees training successors have surfaced, unlike in the customer-service offshoring wave of the 2000s. The unadorned finding is this: positions were eliminated in the United States in the same functions, during the same period, in which positions were being created in India. Jobs disappearing is one fact. Openings in the same functions appearing 8,700 miles away is another. This report prints both and lets them sit side by side.

8. Why Hyderabad — the incentive layer

- Telangana was the first Indian state with a dedicated AVGC policy — the IMAGE Policy (2016): a 25% capital investment subsidy (capped at ₹25 lakh) for qualifying investments creating 50+ jobs, plus power, recruitment, and infrastructure incentives [28][29].
- Hyderabad is India's fastest-growing GCC city: 355–400+ capability centers, 300,000+ workers [23].
- May 2026: Telangana officials cite a \$10–20 billion AI/data-center investment pipeline for Hyderabad [30].
- The courtship was government-to-government on the Indian side: the WBD deal was brokered by the state IT minister in New York [4]; the successor government under Chief Minister Revanth Reddy pitches US investors through the US-India Strategic Partnership Forum, targeting a \$1 trillion state economy by 2034 [31].

9. The political blind spot in Washington

No American politician appears anywhere in the WBD-Hyderabad chain, and the legislative activity that exists points at a different problem:

- **Sen. Adam Schiff (D-CA)** held a field hearing at Burbank City Hall on March 20, 2026 (“Lights, Camera, Competition”), joined by Rep. Laura Friedman (CA-30), whose district contains nearly every major studio [6][32]. His proposal — a federal 15% film-production labor tax credit — is stalled without bipartisan support [33]. The hearing’s focus was production flight to Canada and the UK; the India AI build-out was not raised, per available coverage [6][32].
- **Sen. Bernie Moreno (R-OH)** introduced the HIRE Act (S. 2976, October 6, 2025): a 25% excise tax on outsourcing payments to foreign persons for services benefiting US consumers, plus a deduction ban — the only pending bill that would touch the capability-center model. It was blocked in the Senate [34][35].
- **President Trump’s 100% tariff on foreign-made films** (announced May 4, 2025, repeated September 29, 2025; unimplemented as of mid-2026) targets finished content, not services. A movie tariff would not touch a single Hyderabad requisition [36].

Congress, in short, is legislating against the last offshoring wave (film shoots) while the current one (AI capability) proceeds without a hearing. Two cautions on reading this gap: capability-center hiring is lawful, ordinary corporate activity that no current statute restricts — the absence of hearings may reflect the absence of a policy lever as much as an oversight; and legislators respond to constituencies, and the constituency for production flight (below-the-line crews, visibly idled soundstages) is organized and loud in a way that a diffuse, future-tense capability

shift is not. The blind spot is documented; whether it is negligence or simply the shape of political attention, this report does not judge.

10. The larger pattern: WBD is not alone

- **US AI majors' India commitments, announced within one December 2025 week** (“Over \$50 billion in under 24 hours” — CNBC): Microsoft \$17.5 billion for 2026–29, its largest-ever Asia investment — with the “India South Central” hyperscale region, Microsoft’s largest in India, sited in Hyderabad and going live mid-2026 [37][38]; Google \$15 billion (AI hub plus a 1-gigawatt data center); Amazon \$35 billion through 2030. Combined: roughly \$67.5 billion [37].
- **OpenAI** opened its first India office (New Delhi, August 2025), is expanding to Mumbai and Bengaluru, and hired Uber’s India head to run the country business; India is ChatGPT’s second-largest market [39][40].
- These are companies that benefit from US federal contracts, the \$1 billion-plus in AI funding enacted in 2025, CHIPS Act semiconductor subsidies, and White House-championed infrastructure projects (Stargate, \$500 billion, announced by the President in January 2025) [41][42]. The juxtaposition is factual; this report does not assert that federal dollars flowed to India.
- **The US cross-border venture track:** Lightspeed Venture Partners is the most active investor in Indian generative-AI companies by count, with over \$2.1 billion deployed in India and roughly 35% of its dedicated India fund going to AI; Accel is active through its long-standing India fund [43]. Indian GenAI startups raised \$417 million in 2025 (up 191% year over year) and \$1.07 billion in the first half of 2026 [43][44].
- **The India demand side:** “Hollywood is debating AI. India’s filmmakers are embracing it” [14] — AI artists there report 10–

15 job offers a week; no empowered unions, no AI regulation in force; India’s media and entertainment market is \$32 billion, growing 9% annually [14][45].

11. The map, assembled

Layer	What it shows	Receipt
Job feeds (US)	145 WBD gen-AI reqs, largest of any major	Sec. 2, [9]
Job feeds (geography)	Majority of those reqs in Hyderabad	[3][9]
Role taxonomy	Tech + content operations, not creative development	Sec. 3, [10][11][12]
Salary data	Hyderabad senior engineer ≈ 1/4-1/5 US cost	Sec. 4, [17]–[21]
Company’s own words	Hub builds “global technology platforms... worldwide”	[3]
India press	Announced May 2023 as AI Center of Excellence; ministers at the ribbon	[4][5][22]
Incentives	IMAGE Policy subsidies; GCC ecosystem; \$10–20B state AI pipeline	[28][23][30]
US layoffs	17,000+ M&E cuts in 2025; WBD film group –10%	[15][16]
Executive talk	“People, not systems”; Midjourney suit	[1][2][7]
Washington	Hearings and bills aim at production flight; the one bill touching capability centers is blocked	[6][32]–[36]
Peer pattern	\$67.5B US-tech AI capacity siting in India; OpenAI offices	[37]–[40]
Private money	Lightspeed, Accel in Indian GenAI; \$417M/2025, \$1.07B/H1-2026	[43][44]

Every layer points the same direction. No single fact in this report is secret; several are press releases. The map is what is new.

A closing note on register. Much of the public conversation about AI and entertainment runs on drama — replacement panics on one side, utopian pitches on the other. The record assembled here supports neither. It shows a global company doing what global companies do — placing work where the economics favor it — with one genuinely new element: the work in question is the AI layer itself. Whether that layer ends up augmenting Hollywood’s creative workforce or thinning it is not yet in the record. When it is, it will be reported the same way: from the receipts.

12. Methodology

Job counts come from direct review of the studios’ own careers systems (Workday, Greenhouse, and Eightfold applicant-tracking platforms) on July 22, 2026, cross-checked against Glassdoor and Indeed listings. Counts are point-in-time readings subject to posting churn and keyword-matching error in both directions; cross-company comparisons additionally reflect differences in how each company titles and organizes AI work (see the Sony note, Section 2), so we rely on them only for order-of-magnitude and geographic pattern, not precise rankings. Counts will be re-verified on publication day, and recurring reviews will replace single-day snapshots with multi-date averages as this publication’s history accumulates. Salary figures are market aggregates from Glassdoor, Built In, ZipRecruiter, PayScale, and Levels.fyi as cited; the WBD-specific figures are self-reported employee data from Levels.fyi and should be read as indicative, not official. Indian coverage is cited to named outlets and Telangana government publications. Corporate language is quoted from WBD’s own careers pages. Every claim in this report is reproducible from public sources.

Statements of corporate intent (“talk”) are quoted from public remarks and filings; hiring and investment activity (“walk”) is documented from primary sources. Readers may draw their own conclusions about the distance between the two.

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